AUSTIN BALDI

Senior UX Researcher & Freelance Research Consultant

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PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

Senior UX Researcher and independent consultant with 5+ years driving product decisions in live-service games, SaaS, blockchain, and EdTech. Practiced in both qualitative and quantitative methods -- including survey design and statistical analysis (R, SQL, SPSS), behavioral data analysis, and large-scale quantitative studies -- with a track record of translating mixed-methods findings into concrete changes that improve onboarding, comprehension, and retention. Available for embedded research, usability studies, and strategy consulting with studios and startups that need senior research without full-time overhead.

KEY SKILLS

Qualitative Methods: Moderated & Unmoderated Usability Testing • Think-Aloud Playtesting • Discovery Interviews • Focus Groups • Diary Studies • Concept Validation • Card Sorting • Mental Model Mapping • Heuristic Evaluation
Quantitative Methods: Survey Design & Statistical Analysis • Behavioral Data Analysis • Correlation & Regression (Applied) • R • SQL • SPSS-equivalent workflows • KPI Definition & Tracking • Large-Scale Quantitative Studies
Synthesis: Mixed-Methods Synthesis • Journey Mapping • Cross-Functional Synthesis Workshops • Affinity Mapping
Tools: Figma • UserTesting • Dovetail • Notion • Zoom • Remote Research Platforms

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

User Researcher | **Eldritch House, Brazil (Remote)** *Nov 2025 – Present*
Indie Game Studio

- Conducted early-stage discovery and usability research on core gameplay and onboarding, testing 10+ player hypotheses through structured qualitative and behavioral analysis to validate design assumptions and mitigate development risk.
- Performed moderated playtests with 15–20 representative users per cycle, synthesizing behavioral observations into ranked findings to guide design revisions and improve early player retention.
- Synthesized findings into prioritized top 3–5 high-impact UX changes per sprint; advised leadership on scope and development-cost trade-offs to minimize costly rework.

User Researcher | **Gameloft, Paris, FR (Remote)** *Aug 2023 – Jul 2024*
Disney Speedstorm – Live-Service Mobile Game

- Designed and analyzed surveys and behavioral data studies revealing that ~60% of new players misunderstood rewards and unlocks within their first two sessions -- quantified findings that directly prompted changes to early-game progression strategy.
- Validated progression clarity improvements through follow-up quantitative evaluative testing, measuring a 30–40% reduction in comprehension errors across early gameplay flows.
- Developed a player mental-model-gap framework as a prioritization lens, directly shaping progression messaging and feedback sequencing across multiple seasonal roadmap decisions.
- Produced reusable insight artifacts (journey maps, expectation-gap analyses, fairness indicators) that shortened prioritization cycles by ~20%; owned UX research across 3+ seasonal releases with 25+ players across 4 countries.

UX Researcher | **Kadena, Brooklyn, New York (Remote)** *Oct 2022 – May 2024*

K-Block Blockchain Explorer – Developer Onboarding

- Designed and executed a large-scale quantitative survey study with 100+ respondents, applying statistical analysis to identify and rank confidence and comprehension gaps -- enabling leadership to prioritize changes with evidence rather than assumptions.
- Translated quantitative survey findings and mixed-methods usability data into clear onboarding success criteria, contributing to a measured ~25–30% improvement in onboarding comprehension in follow-up evaluations.
- Mapped end-to-end developer workflows covering 80–90% of common use cases through behavioral analysis, enabling teams to restructure onboarding flows and improve discoverability.
- Facilitated cross-functional synthesis workshops reducing research misinterpretation by ~20%; built reusable research assets cutting setup time by ~15–20% for subsequent studies.

UX Researcher (Volunteer) | **Tech Fleet / AMP UP – Dyslexia Foundation Nigeria** *Jul 2023 – Jan 2026*

Children's Dyslexia Reading App – EdTech, West Africa

- Led multi-phase mixed-methods research (3+ phases) for an open-source educational app targeting dyslexic students in Nigeria -- combining quantitative survey analysis, competitive benchmarking, and qualitative interviews and usability testing.
- Designed and analyzed surveys (15+ responses) alongside qualitative focus groups and interviews with DFN trainers; synthesized quantitative device and connectivity data (97.3% Android) to anchor Android-first, offline-capable design recommendations.
- Developed proto-personas, user stories, journey maps, content style guide, and IA sitemap to align a cross-functional volunteer team across a 2.5-year engagement.

EDUCATION

Bachelor of Arts, Psychology | North Carolina State University, Raleigh, NC *Raleigh, NC*